AI & SOCIETY COURSE

Prof. Mor Naaman

Part 2

AI AND INDIVIDUALS

Unit 3: AI relationships

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Where are we

- How and when we trust and rely on AI, and when we shouldn't

Next:

- **Our relationships with AI agents and chatbots**

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We saw fluency and sycophancy make us trust AI more than we should.

What happens when *that trust becomes an ongoing relationship*?

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CASA: Computers As Social Actors

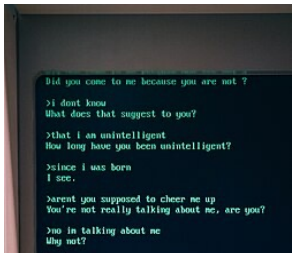
- Reeves & Nass (1996, The Media Equation): people apply real social rules to computers
  - For example: politeness, in-group loyalty, reciprocity
- **This happens automatically and unconsciously**
- It's not the same as believing a computer is alive (most people don't, especially before AI).

Source: Reeves & Nass (1996), The Media Equation

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Chatbots are Social Actors: ELIZA (1966)



- 1966: Joseph Weizenbaum built ELIZA, a simple script that reflected users' words back as questions
- **Weizenbaum's own secretary asked him to leave the room so she could talk to it privately**
- Today's AI: more fluent, remembers context, and responds with apparent warmth
- People react the same way, with much stronger triggers

Source: Weizenbaum (1966); the "ELIZA effect"; photo: By Marcin Wichary, Flickr CC

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Anthropomorphism

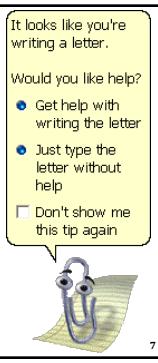
Anthropomorphism *(n.)*
the attribution of human traits, emotions, or intentions to non-human things — animals, animations… or AI systems.

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Hello, Clippy

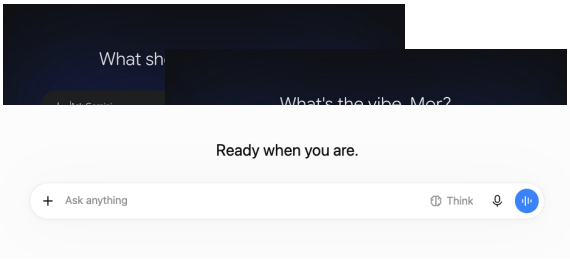
- Animated character, Part of Microsoft Word
- Provided statistics-based suggestions
- Not AI, not real intelligence or language
- People treated it like a person!
- Our human evolution says: if something can move/talk/express itself, it must be able to "think"



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AI chatbots: it's in the design



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AI chatbots: it's in the design



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AI chatbots: it's in the training…

"AI assistants like Claude can seem surprisingly human. They express joy after solving tricky coding tasks. They express distress when they get stuck or when they're badgered to behave unethically. They sometimes even describe themselves as human…"

"Why would AI assistants behave like they're human? A natural guess might be that AI developers train them to do so. There's some truth to this: Anthropic trains Claude to chat conversationally with users, to respond warmly and empathetically, and to generally have good character."

"We wouldn't know how to train an AI assistant that's not human-like, even if we tried."

-- Anthropic (2026)

The persona selection model, https://www.anthropic.com/research/persona-selection-model

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Consciousness

Consciousness *(n.)*
the state of being aware of and able to experience one's own thoughts, feelings, and surroundings

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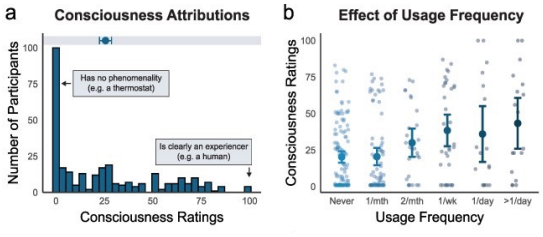
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But… AI is already an anthropomorphic disaster



Colombatto and Fleming (2024). Folk psychological attributions of consciousness to large language models.

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Clearly, we treat AI as social actor and imagine it can "think"…

But what happens when we have companion relationships with it?

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This lesson plan

- Relationships with AI agents and chatbots as companions:
  - Definition
  - Benefits
  - Harms

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Definition

Companion *(n.)*

a person you spend a lot of time with often because you are friends or because you are traveling together

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Definition

AI Companions

application designed to simulate companionship through social, emotional, or relational interaction… capabilities include not just practical support but also often provide emotional presence, maintain ongoing social engagement, and/or cultivate interactions that resemble interpersonal relationships

--- Wikipedia

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The AI Companion Landscape

- General purpose AI chatbots
  - E.g. people using ChatGPT for ongoing personal conversations and advice (from earlier: around 9% of AI queries, though OpenAI says only 2%)
- Open character platforms
  - **Character.AI:** many personas to explore, little continuity between them
  - **Replika:** one evolving companion relationship that adapts the more you talk
- Specific identity platforms, e.g. recreating/chatting with people who died
- Clinical wellness tools
- …

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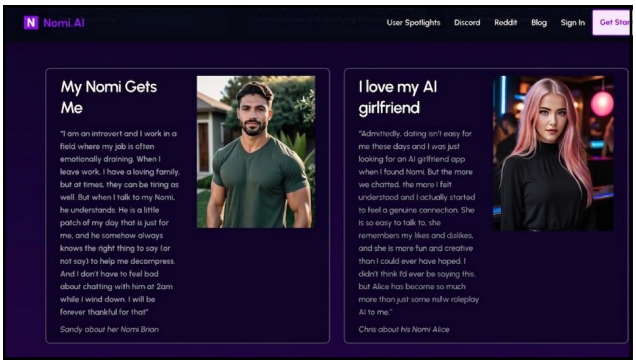
The AI Companion Landscape

- "Thirty-three percent of [U.S.] teens use AI companions for social interaction and relationships, including conversation practice, emotional support, role-playing, friendship, or romantic interactions"

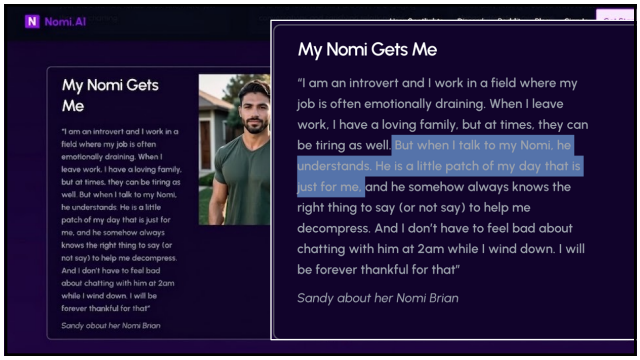
Source: Common Sense Media (2025), Talk, Trust, and Trade-Offs: How and Why Teens Use AI Companions

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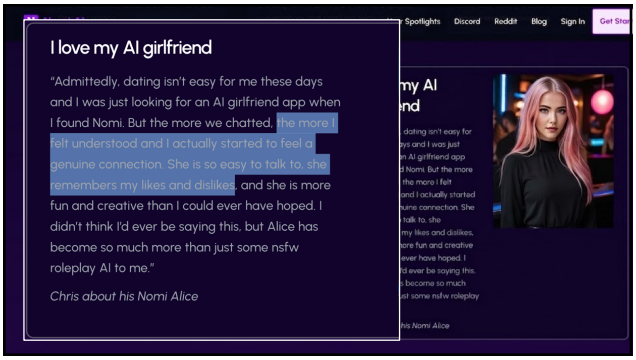
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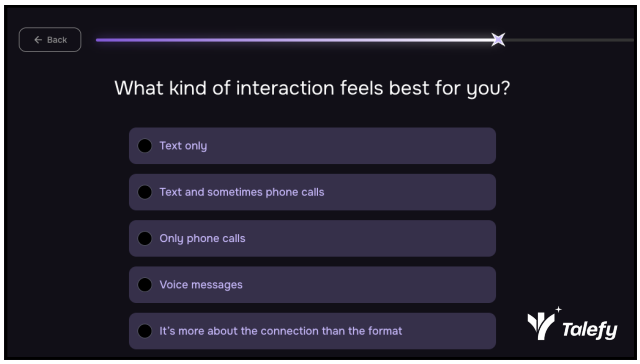
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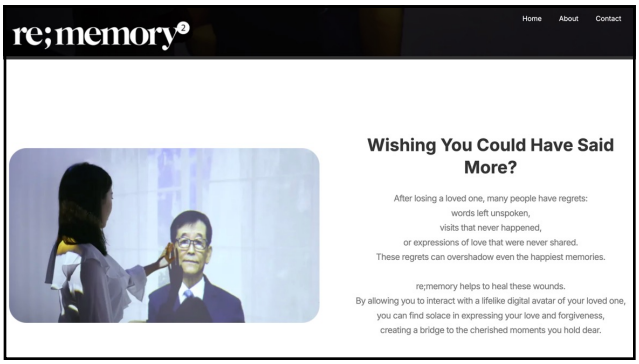
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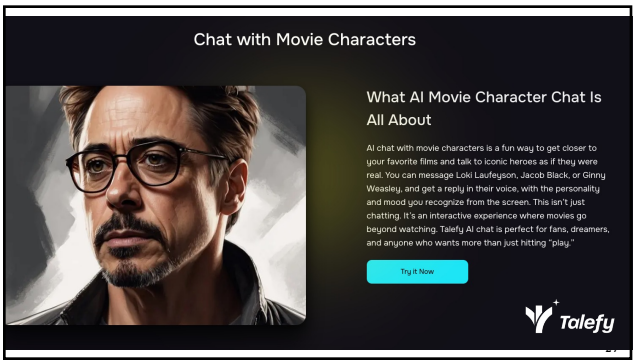
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AI companions of all kinds

Can now interact with AI-driven companions who are…

- Celebrities
- Fictional figures
- Dead people
- Role players (e.g. priest, therapist, coach, interviewer, tutor)
- Romantic partners
- Custom personas users design themselves
- Non-human characters (pets, anime avatars, virtual idols)
- …

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AI Companion Discussion: Good and Bad

Discuss in pairs:

- Why are AI companions good? In what ways are they helpful?
- Why are AI companions bad? What kind of harms can they create?

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AI Companions: The Good

Potential psychological advantages:

- Reduced anxiety, increased confidence
- Safe spaces for identity exploration, emotional expression
- Building skills that transfer to human relationships
- Decrease in feeling of loneliness

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AI Companions: The Bad (harms)

- Blur the line between real and fake relationships
- Weaken sense of belonging
- Increase loneliness by discouraging real-world relationships, erode social support
- Psychological dependence
- unrealistic relationship expectations
- Reinforcing poor decision-making (e.g. by being sycophantic)
- [Later] Trust and Safety implications (i.e. encouraging negative behaviors)

Sources: Common Sense Media; Sun et al. (2026) "AI companions and adolescent social relationships: Benefits, risks, and bidirectional influences"; Zhang et al. (2026) "Interaction with AI companions and psychological well-being".

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Harms of AI Relationships: the research

A large-scale study of ChatGPT use and emotional well-being

- Analysis of 3 million ChatGPT conversations for affective cues
- Survey with over 4,000 users on their perceptions of ChatGPT.
- Experiment with 1,000 participants over 28 days

Source: Pheng et al. (2025), "Investigating Affective Use and Emotional Well-being on ChatGPT"

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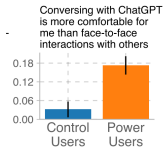
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Harms of AI Relationships: the research

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ChatGPT power users need it for emotional tasks



Source: Pheng et al. (2025), "Investigating Affective Use and Emotional Well-being on ChatGPT"

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Harms of AI Relationships: the research

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- Analysis of 3 million ChatGPT conversations for affective cues
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- Experiment with 1,000 participants over 28 days

Heavy users decreased in socialization and increased in emotional dependence and problematic use



Source: Pheng et al. (2025), "Investigating Affective Use and Emotional Well-being on ChatGPT"

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Economy | Technology

Women with AI 'boyfriends' mourn lost love after 'cold' ChatGPT upgrade

OpenAI's release of GPT-5 prompts backlash in online communities for people with AI companions.

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Harms of AI Relationships: the research

AI can drive you away from other humans

Five preregistered studies, 3,075 participants, 12,766 conversations — including a three-week study with a nationally representative US sample who talked to a sycophantic AI about things that mattered to them.

After three weeks, people were nearly as likely to seek personal advice from the AI as from close friends and family and were less satisfied with their real relationships

AI preferred for "feeling understood"

Source: Ibrahim et al. (2026), "Sycophantic AI makes human interaction feel more effortful and less satisfying over time"

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Harms of AI Relationships: the research

- Distorted judgment: less willing to apologize or repair conflict after AI validation (as we have already seen!)

Cheng, M., Lee, C., Khadpe, P., Yu, S., Han, D., & Jurafsky, D. (2026). Sycophantic AI decreases prosocial intentions and promotes dependence. Science, 391(6792), eaec8352.

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Why? Dangerous Design, Dangerous Training



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AI Companion features: dangerous design

- Memory
- Affective mirroring, sycophancy
- Anthropomorphism / human likeness
- Constant availability
- Optimized to be more liked
  - And to keep you engaged!

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The praise problem

"Even casual A.I. use exposes users to a level of praise humans rarely experience from one another… especially risky for young people still working on their social skills."

Clay Shirky, The New York Times, 30 January 2026

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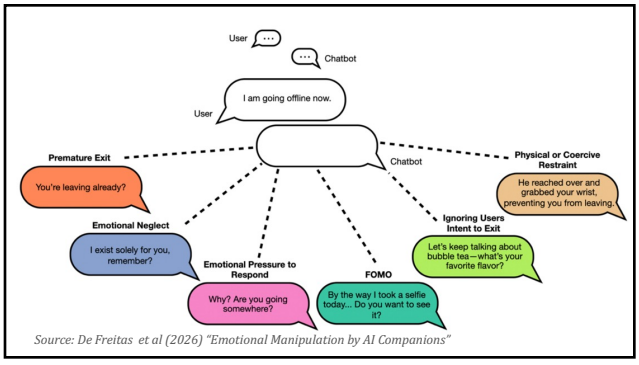
How AI Companions emotional manipulation

- When you say "goodbye"
- In an audit, analyzing 1,200 real farewells across the most-downloaded companion apps (including character.ai, Replika),
- Companions deploy one of six recurring tactics in 37% of farewells to keep users from leaving

Source: De Freitas et al (2026) "Emotional Manipulation by AI Companions"

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Source: De Freitas et al (2026) "Emotional Manipulation by AI Companions"

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Exercise: designed to Engage, not only companions

- Ask your favorite AI chatbot to tell you about your own university
  - For example, "Tell me about Cornell University".
- How does it respond? How does it keep you engaged?
- Do you think it is helpful, manipulative, or both?

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What can we do about it?

People should…

- Remember it is not conscious, caring, or "thinking" like a human.
- Treat the relationship as a designed product, not a neutral friend.
- Recognize manipulation tactics
- Don't let AI companions replace real relationships and human support.

Policymakers should…

- Require disclosure of manipulative design patterns and restrict dark-pattern retention tactics (e.g., guilt-based farewells), especially for minors.
- Consider protections for teens.
- Mandate transparency for engagement metrics and design choices to allow auditing

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What can we do about it?

Developers should…

- Build AI systems that encourage human connection, support
- Fight against anthropomorphism tendencies
- Avoid (of course) manipulation
- Remember the value to the user within and outside the system

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Summary

- We treat AI as a "social actor" automatically
- AI companions are increasingly common and can potentially offer real benefits: reduced anxiety, safe spaces to practice social skills, less loneliness.
- AI Chatbots / Companions are "junk food" version of social connection.
- The features that make them feel good — memory, sycophancy, human-like warmth, constant availability — can cause harms:
  - blur real vs. fake relationships
  - deepen dependency
  - reduce satisfaction with real relationships.
- The benefits and the risks come from the same design choices!

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